militancy within its borders both China and India saw increasing convergence whereas Russia, which had never really viewed India as the strategic lynchpin in Afghanistan, began tilting towards Pakistan and eventually tactically collaborated with the Taliban to counter the rise of ISIS in Afghanistan.[15] Throughout this phase, Iran continued with its own interventionist approach towards Afghanistan. Similar to Pakistan (though of a limited nature) Iran supported certain Afghan Taliban elements.[16] Ironically, unlike its political outbursts against Pakistan, India decided to remain quiet about Iran's interventionism in Afghanistan. The following sections outline these issues in turn. However, they should be read with a note of caution. The following sections are essentially an Indian reading of the situation on the ground in Afghanistan rather than how the (various) reconciliation process(es) actually panned out. The US, British, French, and German advocacy and practice of reconciling with the Taliban, and attempting the same between the Kabul government and Taliban factions, for instance, was highly complicated in nature and character.[17] The diversity, depth, and changing political and military rhythms of these processes will not be captured in this chapter. The idea, instead, is to show how Indian policymakers perceived (correctly or incorrectly) the idea of reconciling with the Taliban depending on who advocated it.

Iraq versus Afghanistan

India witnessed an unprecedented foreign policy debate related to the US invasion of Iraq in 2003. Should US actions be supported or condemned? Relishing an increasingly close relationship with Washington, especially under President Bush, many Indian policymakers supported the invasion despite parliamentary and popular opposition. Similar to the November 2001 request regarding Afghanistan, the US asked for an Indian military contingent in Iraq in 2003. Home minister Advani, a partisan who favoured deeper defence collaboration with the US, was willing to offer such support.[18] But PM Vajpayee, a conciliator, was unconvinced. Initially agreeing to consider the US request for Indian troops in Iraq if there was 'an explicit UN mandate' for the invasion, New Delhi ended up 'deploring' the invasion.[19] Splitting India's body politic and civil